

Standard Operating Procedure for Immediate Action During Cyber Financial Fraud (Golden Hour Response)

Publisher: Cybercrime.gov.in / I4C | **Topic:** immediate_financial_loss_action | **Date:** 2026-10-02
Official Source: https://cybercrime.gov.in/UploadMedia/Immediate_Action_Financial_Loss_SOP.pdf

Official Advisory: SOP: The Golden Hour Protocol for Fraud Recovery

Definition of the 'Golden Hour'

The first 60 to 120 minutes following an unauthorized financial transaction are designated the 'Golden Hour'. During this brief window, funds remain in transit across inter-bank clearing channels, intermediate wallets, or mule accounts. Swift reporting drastically increases the probability of complete fund freezing and full financial recovery.

Immediate Step-by-Step Action Plan

Step 1: IMMEDIATELY dial 1930 (Cyber Fraud Helpline) to trigger real-time inter-bank blocking via CFCFRMS.

Step 2: Contact your bank's 24x7 customer care or fraud desk to block debit/credit cards, disable netbanking access, and revoke UPI registration.

Step 3: Register an online complaint at cybercrime.gov.in to obtain a formal complaint acknowledgement number.

Step 4: Request your bank to initiate a 'chargeback' or 'lien request' referencing the 1930 acknowledgement number.

Preservation of Critical Digital Evidence

Do not delete messages, call logs, or application files from your device. Take full-screen screenshots displaying sender IDs, timestamps, URLs, and account numbers. Download official bank account statements reflecting the debited transaction and reference numbers.

Zero Liability Guidelines (RBI Directive)

Under RBI circular DBR.No.Leg.BC.78/09.07.005/2017-18, if an unauthorized electronic transaction is reported to the bank within three working days and does not involve customer negligence, customer liability is zero. Rapid formal reporting is critical to legal protection.

Citizen Action Checklist & Red Flags

- **Verify Sender Identity:** Always check official website addresses and header IDs (e.g., VM-SBI, AX-HDFC). Scammers use fake sender masks.
- **Never Share Authentication Secrets:** Passwords, OTPs, UPI PINs, and debit card CVVs are strictly confidential. Bank staff will NEVER ask for them.
- **Independent Verification:** If you receive a threat or alert about an account freeze, call the official bank branch number found on your physical card or bank statement.
- **Immediate Reporting:** Report cyber financial fraud within the Golden Hour by calling 1930 or visiting cybercrime.gov.in.

Frequently Asked Questions (Regulatory Clarifications)

Q1: Can money be deposited into my bank account by entering my UPI PIN?

A: No. A UPI PIN is solely an authorization to debit funds from your linked bank account. Receiving funds requires NO authentication or PIN entry.

Q2: What is the first action to take if money is fraudulently deducted?

A: Dial 1930 immediately to register the complaint on the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre (I4C) CFCFRMS portal so that the beneficiary account can be frozen before funds are withdrawn.

Q3: What should I do if an unknown caller threatens me with a police arrest over video call?

A: Disconnect immediately. Indian police and law enforcement agencies never issue summons, conduct investigations, or

place citizens under 'Digital Arrest' via video calls.

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